The IPA Journey

By Milena Jeremic | March 18, 2026

Data Kudos

The Institutional Planning and Analytics (IPA) project's mission is to build a unified, data analytics platform where the right data is accessible to the right people at the right time. The project, led by Karen Furlonge, Brad Strom, Keshia Gray, Margaret Kierylo, and Ramon Kagan, will provide a secure, scalable solution that gives our community access to actionable insights, enabling us to drive innovation, whether it's enrolment planning or data analytics.

Without IPA, we are left using existing on-premises, legacy solutions and tools, such as SAS and Oracle, that limit continuous integration and deployment. Our current multi-source data pool is time intensive, which creates bottlenecks and inefficiencies. With no error handling, there isn't a way to provide alerts for missing or incorrect data values. The IPA project addresses these problems by developing and deploying an advanced analytics platform utilizing Microsoft Azure Data Services, which enhances data analytics capabilities, improves scalability, and supports institutional planning and reporting. It ensures that the University can handle large datasets more efficiently, facilitate near real-time data processing, and support strategic planning with actionable insights, all of which will help to provide a robust, centralized system that will democratize data to support informed decision-making and reporting.

The 5 Goals of the IPA Project

Establish a modern, unified data & analytics platform

- **Single Source of Truth**
  A unified data platform eliminates silos, ensuring everyone has access to consistent, reliable information from vetted sources.
- **Faster, Easier Reporting**
  Automated data pipelines and standardized frameworks drastically reduce manual effort and delays.

Improve data quality, integrity & governance

- **Trusted, High-Quality Data**
  Strong validation rules and governance practices ensure accurate, reliable, and consistent information
- **Responsible & Ethical Use**
  Data is accessed and used only for its intended purpose, in alignment with York's mission, values, privacy expectations, and ethical standards
- **Robust Governance & Compliance**
  Clear stewardship roles, access controls, and adherence to York's policies and retention requirements promote secure, compliant, and transparent data management

Enhance institutional reporting & decision-making

- **Enhanced Decision-Making**
  Advanced analytics and predictive modelling help identify trends, forecast outcomes, and support proactive decisions.
- **Faster, Easier Reporting**
  Reporting automation enhanced by Natural Language Processing (NLP) enables faster, more accurate outputs.
- **Automate Processes**
  Reduces manual intervention, freeing staff to focus on analysis and strategy.

Drive efficiency, collaboration & knowledge sharing

- **Automate Processes**
  Streamlined workflows reduce manual work to extract data which results in reporting delays.

- **Greater Efficiency and Scalability**
  A scalable solution that grows with the demands and needs of the institution.
- **Enhanced Decision-Making**
  Staff collaboration and knowledge sharing improve insights and response time.

Support long-term innovation & scalability

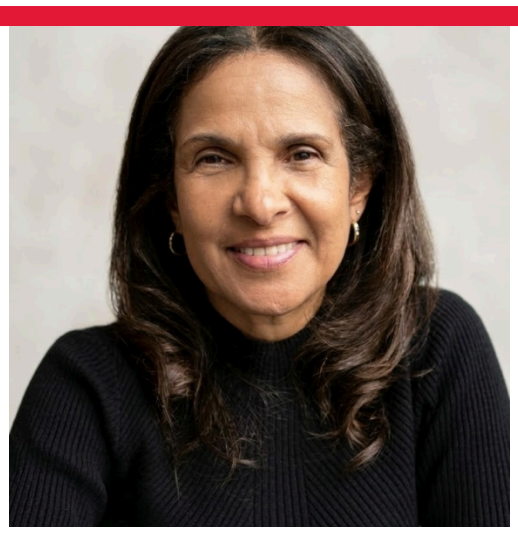
- **Future-Ready Innovation**
  Modern infrastructure built for emerging technologies and new use cases.
- **Greater Efficiency and Scalability**
  Dynamic scaling supports growth and cost optimization.
- **Governance, Security and Compliance**
  Continued protection of institutional data while innovating responsibly.

Kudos

We wanted to take a moment to recognize some individuals without whom this project could not have not progressed in the ways it has.

Meenakshi Shankar

James Niu



Karen Furlonge

Firstly, we would like to recognize Meenakshi Shankar, our data engineering lead. Meena has been instrumental in designing the data model, establishing naming conventions and development standards, conducting code reviews, implementing data quality checks with robust exception handling, and mentoring team members. Her guidance has helped ensure the project is built on a sustainable technical foundation, and, quite fittingly, she has proven to be truly exceptional when it comes to exception handling.

Next, we would like to recognize James Niu, our data quality analyst, affectionately nicknamed "*the encyclopedia.*" James works closely with the team to interpret the government reporting requirements, ensuring that the rules are applied consistently and accurately. Data quality is a critical component of the IPA initiative, and James plays a key role in maintaining that standard. He is responsible for validating the data against the reporting requirements, identifying and flagging any data quality issues for follow-up, and documenting the results to support transparency and accountability.

We also need to take a moment to spotlight Karen Furlonge, the Project Lead and driving force of this initiative. Karen consistently keeps the team focused on the bigger picture, ensuring that we look beyond the technical perspective and maintain a strong focus on the end-user experience.. She advocates for designing with users in mind, emphasizing that the new data must be intuitive and accessible, enabling our community to obtain the right information without needing an advanced understanding of the underlying business processes or technology.

She provides support for the team, helping to remove obstacles and ensuring everyone has what they need to succeed. As the UIT representative, she engages with the York data and analytics community to highlight the transformative power of the new IPA platform. Karen had a few words to share on IPA's journey and impact:

> This project began with a clear and important goal: to ensure that our data is accurate, consistent, and meaningful for those who rely on it. By carefully defining requirements and applying business rules consistently, the team has worked to build a strong foundation for reliable data and trusted insights.
>
> Along the way, the project has become more than a technical initiative—it has been a collaborative journey driven by a shared commitment to meaningful change. Teams from OIPA, OUR, and UIT have come together, combining their expertise and supporting one another to overcome challenges.

The IPA project represents a significant step forward, transforming our data and analytics capabilities. It's not just about better data – it's about enabling and empowering better decisions for our community.